EL NIÑO ACTION BRIEFING · 16 OCTOBER 2026

Atwater Village, Los Angeles

In Atwater Village, El Niño's danger runs in the river, not through the houses. Every recorded rescue on this reach has been on the islands of the Glendale Narrows, among people who live there. Warnings have not moved them; a worker they know, offering a place that takes their dog, their cart, and their partner, can. That work has to start now, in the dry weeks.

IMPACT REGION	EXCESS HEAT DEATHS	WINDOW	DOMINANT HAZARD
A Los Angeles County impact region (inferred; the county's ~9.7M people span many regions, and the specific one was not resolved)	None published for the US, California, or Los Angeles County	Global 6-month figure 239,000 ± 11,000 (Sep 2026 – Feb 2027); not scaled here	Winter storms in the LA River channel, then Santa Ana heat, red-flag winds, and outages

12/12 recommendations checked. 2 confirmed, 10 corrected, 0 unverified, 0 contraindicated. Four practices are flagged *do not do*. Exposure figure: Climate Impact Lab, September 2026, pre-peer-review, heat only. No figure is published for anywhere in the US, so none is borrowed or scaled. **The funding target fell 68% in verification**, from $95,280 to $30,000, because storm beds are already publicly funded and the winter bed rate is $89, not $116.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY — AT A GLANCE



34.12°N 118.27°W, United States of America · Natural Earth

- **The risk.** The LA River's Glendale Narrows: LAFD pulled people off islands at Fletcher Dr (2019) and Glendale Blvd (2020), and a boy swept in upstream was found on an island at Los Feliz (2017).
- **First action.** County homeless services and PATH build a by-name list of everyone living in the channel and an intake that takes dogs, carts, and partners, ready before the first Flood Watch.
- **The money.** $18,000 / $30,000 / $171,400; the best dollar buys guarded storage for belongings, the reason people stay in the channel.
- **Do not.** Do not clear encampments or take belongings in the weeks before storms; it pushes people deeper into the channel.

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* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Where this is. Atwater Village (ZIP 90039) sits between the Los Angeles River and Interstate 5 on the west and the Glendale city line on the east. Just north of the line, Glendale ZIP 91204 is served by Glendale Water & Power and Glendale's emergency services, not LADWP and the City of Los Angeles. This briefing covers Atwater Village as a whole. The neighbourhood is in City Council District 13; the opposite bank, Griffith Park and Los Feliz, is in District 4. ZIP 90039 has 28,884 people, a median age of 40.7, and a median household income of $113,818, with 10% below the poverty line (ACS 2024). About 28% were born abroad, and Spanish and Tagalog are the main home languages after English.

What the forecast says. NOAA's Climate Prediction Center (8 October 2026) puts an 83% chance on a historic El Niño (≥+2.5 °C) for October–December, and a strong to very strong event is likely through January–March 2027. Its 15 October outlook favours an above-normal California rain season and gives Equal Chances on Southwest temperature for November–January. Here, El Niño means winter storms, mostly from January to March. It does not reliably bring autumn heat, but Santa Ana heat and red-flag winds come in October and November every year, El Niño or not, so the heat actions below are for the season, not the event.

WHAT THIS PLACE SHOULD DO

RANKED

Ranked by expected lives saved per unit of effort before the peak. Backing lenses are shown per action; an action several lenses reached

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independently is the stronger bet. The first two are about the river and must start in October; the next three cover heat and outages this autumn.

1. Build a by-name list of everyone living in the river channel from Los Feliz Blvd to Colorado Blvd, through outreach workers the camps already know, and an intake that takes dogs, carts, and partners, with guarded storage, ready before the first Flood Watch

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED · EMERGENCY MGR · SKEPTIC · FRONTLINE · HISTORIAN · PHILANTHROPIST · PUBLIC HEALTH · FOOD

INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
LA County Department of Homeless Services and Housing (HSH), confirming in writing whether HSH or LAHSA runs storm response this winter; PATH and county outreach teams do the visits; the CD13 office convenes	Visits from now, weekly; list and intake by 15 Nov	Outreach within existing contracts; storage and kennels $10,000 (assumed, see funding); beds from the public Winter Shelter and Emergency Response program	Drownings and island strandings when the Narrows rises

Warnings alone have failed here. On 16 May 2019, LAFD, LAPD, and the HOPE team warned the camps before the storm, and two people were still stranded on an island north of Fletcher Drive; a man who went in to help was carried half a mile downriver. What has worked is the same team coming back. PATH's river work for Council District 4 (Fletcher Dr to Griffith Park, 2022–23) engaged 160 people and housed 60, and an Abt Associates study of that work found that consistent visits by one team were what moved people. Atwater's own bank has no equivalent contract that we could find. In April 2023, after weeks of outreach, a Council District 3 operation moved 44 people from the river into motels before a storm. Pair the visits with an intake that accepts animals, carts, and couples, plus tagged storage, because losing those is why people stay. Stock it with ready-to-eat food that needs no cooking or can opener. The Winter Shelter and Emergency Response program already activates on an NWS Flood Watch or Warning (it did on 14 November and 22 December 2025).

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Corrections: the published activation criteria differ between LAHSA's page (a 1-inch-in-24-hours forecast, three days of ¼ inch, or a Flood Watch) and 211 LA's (three days of rain at or below 50 °F, or a Flood Watch), so the Flood Watch is the dependable trigger. Who runs storm response is unsettled: a Board of Supervisors motion moves it to HSH, but LAHSA still ran Winter Shelter in February 2026. No study shows pre-storm outreach reduces drownings. The CD3 operation was in the West Valley, not the Narrows. How many people sleep on the Atwater reach is not counted anywhere.

2. On every Flood Watch night, stage LAFD swift-water crews at the Narrows (Los Feliz Blvd, Glendale Blvd, Fletcher Dr) with the outreach list's map of where people sleep, and count everyone by name after each storm

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | EMERGENCY MGR · HISTORIAN · SKEPTIC | INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Los Angeles Fire Department; outreach teams supply the map and run the head count	Agreed by 15 Nov; runs on each NWS Flood Watch through March	Within LAFD's existing storm pre-deployment	Rescues that depend on a passer-by, and a missing person going unnoticed for days

LAFD already pre-deploys swift-water teams citywide before storms; in November 2025 it staffed three state-augmented teams, an urban search-and-rescue team, and helicopters around the clock. What is new is placing them at the islands and giving them a map. On 28 December 2020 a man and a woman were stranded on an island just south of Glendale Blvd in water 3–4 feet deep moving at 5–8 mph. They were found only because a passer-by called at 3:31am, and the rescue took 65 minutes. In February 2017, 14-year-old Elias Rodriguez was swept into the Pacoima Wash and found eight days later on a river island near I-5 at Los Feliz. A by-name count after each storm turns "is anyone missing?" from a guess into a list.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Corrections: pre-deployment exists; Narrows-specific staging and the shared map are the proposal, and they are untested. The 2020 call was at 3:31am, not 2:30am.

3. On every major or extreme HeatRisk day, Red Flag Warning, and long outage through November, phone or knock on a named list of older residents who live alone, are bedbound, or use powered medical equipment

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | PUBLIC HEALTH · EMERGENCY MGR · FRONTLINE · PHILANTHROPIST · SKEPTIC | INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
LA County Department of Public Health; Assistance League of Southern California's Hollywood Senior Multipurpose Center makes the calls; Atwater Village Neighborhood Council recruits Spanish- and Tagalog-speaking volunteers	List and callers by 1 Nov; through 30 Nov, then on outages all winter	$15,000 for 150 people over 10 weeks (assumed rate; see funding)	Heat and outage deaths indoors among isolated and bedbound people

The federal emPOWER map counts 4,856 Medicare beneficiaries in 90039. Of them, 146 use power-dependent equipment, 32 have in-centre dialysis, 23 are on oxygen, 37 get home health care, and 11 are in home hospice (queried 16 October 2026). Another 112 are power-dependent in Glendale 91204. In the 1995 Chicago heat wave, being confined to bed raised the odds of death 8.2 times and living alone 2.3 times (Semenza et al., NEJM 1996). In a meta-analysis, not leaving home daily raised them 3.35 times, and social contact cut them by 60% (Bouchama et al., Arch Intern Med 2007). The Hollywood center lists Atwater in its service area, and its nutrition site at 3356 Glendale Blvd already has a list of the neighbourhood's isolated older people.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Corrections: a named emPOWER list goes only to the state health department, and only during a declared incident, so it cannot be the routine call list; use the counts to size it and build the names from the nutrition site, LADWP's Life-Support customers, and door-knocking. The evidence is observational and from Chicago and Europe. The $10 a week rate is assumed. A Philadelphia warning system was modelled to save 117 lives for about $210,000 (Teisberg, Ebi et al., BAMS 2004), but that bought a whole system, not just calls. Tagalog-speaking volunteers were not confirmed.

4. Before storm and wind season, make sure the 23 oxygen users and 32 dialysis patients in 90039 have a backup that does not depend on the grid, and enrol them in LADWP's Life-Support Equipment discount

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | PUBLIC HEALTH · SKEPTIC · EMERGENCY MGR | INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
LA County Department of Public Health, with oxygen suppliers, dialysis units, and LADWP; the action 3 callers ask the question	**1 Dec**	**Backup cylinders normally from suppliers; enrolment free**	**Deaths when a storm or wind outage lasts longer than a device's battery**

LADWP's 2026 Wildfire Mitigation Plan says it phones Life-Support Discount customers whose outage tolerance is eight hours or less when its system predicts an outage will hit them. Its own form says the discount does not guarantee supply or restoration and urges an independent backup. LADWP has no public safety power shutoff program yet, but fire authorities can ask it to cut lines. The 2003 New York blackout raised accidental deaths by 122% and other deaths by 25% (Anderson and Bell, Epidemiology 2012).*

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Corrections: the emPOWER dialysis count is in-centre, not home, dialysis, so the question is each unit's storm plan. Enrolment needs a medical review. Homes just north of the Glendale line are served by Glendale Water & Power, which has its own program. The blackout study measures harm, not this action's effect.

5. Enrol low-income households in LADWP's EZ-SAVE discount so they cannot be shut off and qualify for the $275 Cool LA air-conditioner rebate, and ask the LADWP Board to add Red Flag Warnings to its shutoff pause

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | ECONOMIST · PUBLIC HEALTH · SKEPTIC | INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
LADWP (programs and Board); the Neighborhood Council and action 3's callers run sign-up	Enrolment from now; Board motion by 1 Dec	Rebates paid by LADWP ratepayers; outreach volunteer time; the pause defers debt rather than forgiving it	Heat deaths in homes with no cooling, and shutoffs during dangerous weather

A working air conditioner is the strongest protective factor in the heat-death literature: it lowered the odds of death to 0.3 in Chicago in 1995 (Semenza) and to 0.23 in a meta-analysis (Bouchama). EZ-SAVE's income limit is $43,280 for one or two people (from 1 July 2026). Since a Board motion of 8 November 2022, enrolled EZ-SAVE and Senior Lifeline customers cannot be shut off for debt. Discount customers get up to $275 per unit ($50 plus a limited-time $225 top-up) for up to two window, wall, or portable units. Others get up to $125, for window units only. The discount must be active when the unit is bought. Since 27 June 2023, LADWP has paused shutoffs for everyone in a district under an NWS heat or cold alert, but not under a Red Flag Warning, which is when Santa Ana heat arrives.

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Corrections: shutoff protection for enrolled customers already exists; enrolment is the new work. The Red Flag extension would mainly help households not enrolled. The $225 top-up has no end date and can be withdrawn without notice. Units bought now protect people mostly next autumn.

6. If a home is in a flood zone or has taken water before, buy flood insurance by about 10 November, because it takes 30 days to start and the federal program's authority lapses on 11 December

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | ECONOMIST | INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Households; FEMA's National Flood Insurance Program (NFIP) through any agent	Buy by ~10 Nov	About $2,165 a year all-in at the ZIP average ($1,696 premium)	Uninsured flood and mudflow losses; homeowner policies and the FAIR Plan exclude flood

OpenFEMA shows about 135 NFIP policies in force in 90039 (1 June 2026): 42 in zone AO, 9 in zone A, and 87 in zone X. Since 1978 the ZIP has had 23 claims, with $233,239 paid. The worst year by count was 1980 (7 claims, $62,024) and by value 2023 (one claim, $74,110). The program's authority runs only to 11 December 2026 unless Congress extends it; it lapsed for 43 days in October–November 2025 before being restored retroactively. A policy bought after about 10 November may not start before then. The California FAIR Plan covers fire only.

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Corrections: a "34 flood-zone addresses" figure from the panel had no source and was dropped; OpenFEMA counts policies, not addresses. The number of housing units at risk was not checked against FEMA flood maps. NFIP covers mudflow but not landslide.

7. Screen people living along the river, and other outreach clients, for CalFresh work-rule exemptions before they lose benefits, as part of the same outreach visits

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | FOOD | INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
LA County Department of Public Social Services (DPSS), joining the action 1 outreach teams	20 Oct – 30 Nov	Within DPSS's exemption work, directed by the Board in October 2025; no separate budget found	Losing food benefits just as storms force evacuations

The region's food supply is not what breaks here: trucks reroute around Grapevine closures, and USDA expects food-at-home prices up 2.4% in 2026 (fresh vegetables up 5.7%). What breaks is a household's ability to buy and cook food. Under the 2025 federal budget law, CalFresh work rules took effect in California on 1 June 2026. They ended the automatic exemption for people experiencing homelessness and widened the age range to 18–64. Supervisor Solis estimated that about 260,000 of the county's roughly 1.5 million CalFresh participants are affected. People living in the channel cannot store or cook food and are the first to be moved in a storm.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Corrections: current recipients become subject to the rules at recertification, so cutoffs come in waves from about September, not on a single date. The panel's $50,000 cost was unsourced and was dropped. Federal cuts to administrative cost-sharing from October strain DPSS's capacity.

8. Before the first Red Flag Warning, the City of Los Angeles and Glendale test their alerts together along the Los Angeles–Glendale line and agree in writing who issues evacuation orders there

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | EMERGENCY MGR | INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
LA City Emergency Management Department, with Glendale's emergency management	Early November	Staff time	A late or duplicated evacuation order on a street split between two cities

In the January 2025 Eaton Fire, a Santa Ana wind event, 19 people died and west Altadena was alerted late. The county's after-action report blamed outdated alert policy, understaffing, and possibly downed cell towers. Streets here run across the Los Angeles–Glendale line, so a fire coming off the Verdugos or Griffith Park would cross two alert systems. LAFD confirms the city uses Genasys Protect evacuation zones. Cal Fire's 2025 maps put part of Atwater Village in a fire hazard zone for the first time.

Corrections: Glendale's alert vendor, the hazard tier for Atwater, and the evacuation zones along the city line were not verified (look the zone up at protect.genasys.com). The 1 November date is tight.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

WHO DOES WHAT

RACI CHART

R = Responsible (does the work) · **A** = Accountable (one per action; signs off and answers for it) · **C** = Consulted (asked before) · **I** = Informed (told after). Built from the owners named in the verified actions. No one here has been contacted or has agreed to a role; every row is a proposal.

Action	County HSH	PATH / outreach	CD13 office	LAFD	County DPH	Assistance League	Neighborhood Council	LADWP	DPSS	City EMD	Glendale	Households
1. River list and intake	**A**	**R**	**R**	**I**	**C**		**C**		**C**	**I**		
2. Swift-water staging and head count	**C**	**R**	**I**	**A/R**						**C**		
3. Named check-ins			**I**		**A**	**R**	**R**	**C**				
4. Backup for oxygen and dialysis					**A**	**R**		**R**			**C**	**R**
5. EZ-SAVE and Red Flag pause			**C**			**R**	**R**	**A/R**				**I**
6. Flood insurance by 10 Nov							**C**			**I**		**A/R**
7. CalFresh exemption screening	**C**	**R**	**I**						**A/R**			
8. Alert test on the city seam			**I**	**C**			**I**			**A/R**	**R**	**I**

What the chart shows: the river actions (1, 2, and 7) rest on the outreach teams, and they only work if HSH confirms who runs storm response this winter, which is a decision, not money. The County Department of Public Health is accountable for both of the actions that protect older and power-dependent residents. Actions 5, 6, and 8 need a signature or a phone call rather than funding.

WHERE MONEY DOES THE MOST

FUNDING

The Philanthropist lens, reconciled against the ranked actions and verified. Placements are ranked by marginal lives saved per dollar. The envelope is bounded by what this place can spend before the peak, not by what it needs.

FLOOR

$18,000: storage and kennels ($10,000) plus check-ins for 100 people for 8 weeks ($8,000)

TARGET

$30,000: the sum of the three verified placements

CEILING

$171,400, if the public storm-bed program runs out and the library can take funding

LARGEST UNCERTAINTY

How many people sleep on the Atwater reach; nobody has counted

Floor: $10,000 + 100 × $10 × 8 weeks = $18,000. Without the storage, action 1 does not change behaviour. Target: $10,000 + 150 × $10 × 10 weeks ($15,000) + 200 packs × $25 ($5,000) = $30,000. Ceiling: contingent storm bed-nights 80 × 15 × $89 ($106,800) + storage $15,000 + check-ins 250 × $10 × 12 ($30,000) + library hours 6 days × 4 h × $400 ($9,600) + 400 packs ($10,000) = $171,400. **The target fell 68% in verification**, from $95,280. The panel's $55,680 for storm beds duplicated the public Winter Shelter and Emergency Response program, which already pays for beds and motel vouchers on a Flood Watch, and used the $116 year-round rate instead of the $89 winter rate. Library hours are set by the city and could not be shown to accept donor money. If HSH confirms in writing that emergency capacity ran out, beds come back at

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40 × 12 × $89 = $42,720, which would make the target $72,720. The 40 people, $10 a week, $25 a pack, and $10,000 for storage are all assumptions.

RECIPIENT	USE	AMOUNT	MECHANISM	BASIS	VERDICT
PATH (or the operator HSH names)	Action 1: guarded, tagged storage and kennel space at the storm intake	$10,000	Direct grant	Assumed figure; no published rate. The only part of storm intake not already paid for publicly. PATH ran this reach for CD4 (160 engaged, target 60).	Partially confirmed
Assistance League of Southern California, Hollywood Senior Multipurpose Center	Action 3: heat, red-flag, and outage check-ins for 150 isolated people 60+	$15,000	Direct grant tied to enrolment	150 × $10 a week (assumed) × 10 weeks. Precedent: Philadelphia's warning system, modelled at 117 lives saved for about $210,000 over 1995–98 (Teisberg, Ebi et al., BAMS 2004), a whole system and not calls alone	Partially confirmed
Los Angeles Regional Food Bank	Action 1: no-cook, no-can-opener 3-day food packs at the storm intake	$5,000	Pre-positioned stock	200 packs × $25 (assumed). The Food Bank and Abbott are pre-staging 1,000 disaster packs for El Niño; their contents and cost are unpublished. Get a quote.	Unverified
LA County HSH Emergency Response program	Action 1: storm bed-nights, only if public capacity runs out	$0 (ceiling $106,800)	Top-up, paid per verified bed-night on a Flood Watch	$89 winter bed rate, 1 Nov 2026 – 31 Mar 2027 (LA CAO, November 2025)	Partially confirmed
LA Public Library, Atwater Village Branch	Extended heat-day hours	$0 (ceiling $9,600)	Only if LAPL confirms in writing	Assumed $400 an hour; branches cool during regular hours set by the city	Partially confirmed

The funder's one thing: the river already has public money for beds. What it lacks is the reason to use them. Fund the storage locker and the kennel, not another bed. If a shelter provider asks for a block grant, pay per verified bed-night instead: Ascencia in Glendale ran a $903,022 deficit on $6.0 million of revenue in FY2025, and its audit found a significant deficiency in internal controls.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Do not do this

CONTRAINDICATED · ADVICE THAT WOULD COST LIVES HERE

Advice that circulates for this hazard and would cost lives here.

Do not clear encampments or take people's belongings in the Narrows in the weeks before storms

CONTRAINDICATED

Clearing camps pushes people farther into the channel and destroys the trust the warning will depend on. In Abt's study, river residents said repeated clean-ups drove them to the river. Outreach usually reached the camps only during sweeps, so people learned to distrust anyone in a vest. On 13 February 2025, during an atmospheric river, the city said an Inside Safe operation in Echo Park brought 17 people indoors. Residents said about a dozen were left in the rain and their belongings were run over. That account comes from one outlet. The city's own CARE+ rules normally bar removing tents in rain or below 50 °F.

Instead: keep visits going without clean-ups from now through March, and offer a guarded locker and a held bed to each named person, so leaving costs them nothing they own.

Do not count a warning walk, flyers, or a single pre-storm sweep as the evacuation plan

CONTRAINDICATED

On 16 May 2019, the camps north of Fletcher Drive were warned before the storm, and people were still on the island when the water rose. In January 2016, sheriff's and LAHSA teams walked the San Gabriel River warning residents, who declined to move (La Opinión, 5 January 2016). Agencies count contacts made and beds offered, not people still in the channel.

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Instead: use actions 1 and 2. The same workers visit repeatedly, each person's way out is agreed before any Flood Watch, and the count after each storm, of who is still in the Narrows, is published.

Do not treat a cooling-centre list or a heat alert as the heat plan

CONTRAINDICATED

Across US Medicare data, heat-alert days showed no lower mortality (RR 1.005; Weinberger et al., Environ Int 2021). City cooling centres averaged about 11 visitors per site per day over Labor Day 2020 and about 21 in 2022, and UCLA found that use rose only at sites within a quarter mile of transit. The Atwater Village Branch Library (3379 Glendale Blvd) is on the county's August 2026 cooling list. It closes at 5:30pm on Fridays and Saturdays and all day Sunday, and the Silver Lake branch is closed for construction.

Instead: action 3's calls and visits, plus a ride to the library during its open hours for anyone the callers find without cooling.

Do not tell older people to sit in front of an electric fan on a dry Santa Ana day above about 37 °C (99 °F)*

CONTRAINDICATED

A biophysical modelling study (Morris et al., Lancet Planetary Health 2021) found that fans stop helping healthy older adults above about 38 °C, and above about 37 °C for people on anticholinergic medicines. In hot, dry air they can add heat rather than remove it. That is the profile of a Santa Ana day: Woodland Hills reached 121 °F on 6 September 2020.

Instead: below those temperatures a fan is fine. Above them, wet the skin and fan it, and go to a cooled room. This is the message for action 3's callers.

WHAT HAS HAPPENED HERE BEFORE — THE RECORD

YEAR	EVENT	TOLL	WHAT CHANGED AFTER
1933	Griffith Park fire, across the river: relief workers sent to fight it were trapped	29 dead	The deadliest fire in Los Angeles history

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

YEAR	EVENT	TOLL	WHAT CHANGED AFTER
1938 (Mar)	Los Angeles flood	About 87–115+ across the region, depending on the source	The Army Corps paved the river; the Glendale Narrows stayed soft-bottomed because of its high water table, which is why it has islands
1969 (Jan–Feb)	Southern California storms (moderate El Niño)	60 to 100+, depending on the source	More flood-control building
1982–83	Very strong El Niño storms	36 dead statewide	Not found
1997–98	Very strong El Niño storms	17 dead statewide	Not found
2007 (May)	Griffith Park fire, about 817 acres	No deaths; about 2,000 Los Feliz customers lost power	Not found
2015–16	Very strong El Niño: city pre-storm outreach to river channels	About 800 people estimated in county riverbeds and flood channels (Marketplace, Nov 2015)	Warning walks; residents largely did not move
2017 (Feb)	Elias Rodriguez, 14, swept into the Pacoima Wash, found on a river island near I-5 at Los Feliz	1 dead	Nothing found
2018 (Nov 29)	Man airlifted from a tree about a quarter mile south of Colorado Blvd	0	Nothing found
2019 (May 16)	Two people stranded on an island north of Fletcher Dr after a pre-storm warning; a rescuer was swept half a mile	0; three rescued	Nothing found

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YEAR	EVENT	TOLL	WHAT CHANGED AFTER
2020 (Sep 6)	Heat wave: 121 °F at Woodland Hills, the county record	Not published for this area; LADWP outages peaked near 70,000 customers	LADWP's 2023 heat- and cold-alert shutoff pause
2020 (Dec 28)	Two people stranded on an island just south of Glendale Blvd; found by a passer-by at 3:31am	0; two rescued	Nothing found
2022	LA County heat deaths	Unhoused people were 5 of 12 coroner-recorded heat deaths, while under 1% of the population	County heat-mortality dashboard, May 2026
2025 (Jan)	Eaton Fire, a Santa Ana wind event, east of here	19 dead	After-action report on late alerts

The recurrence nobody has noticed: the Narrows were left unpaved in the 1930s because the water table was too high. That left the islands, which are now celebrated as the river's natural stretch and are exactly where people sleep and get trapped. Paving the rest of the river moved the danger off Atwater's houses and onto its poorest residents, much as the 1933 fire killed the men on relief who had been sent to fight it. Every rescue on this reach since 2018 has been of people living on the river, and none has been of people in houses.

WHERE THE EXPERTS DISAGREE — UNRESOLVED

- **Pre-storm outreach moves people indoors** (Historian: 44 moved in CD3, April 2023) versus **warnings have never cleared this reach** (Emergency manager and Skeptic: Fletcher Dr, 2019). The two are reconciled by Abt's finding that one-off warnings fail while repeat visits by the same team work. The evidence that would settle it is the published count of people still in the Narrows after each storm.
- **El Niño raises autumn heat risk here** versus **it does not**. The Public health scientist and NOAA's outlook find no El Niño autumn heat signal for coastal Southern California. The heat actions stay because Santa Ana heat comes every autumn, not because of this event.
- **Fund storm beds** (Philanthropist, Economist) versus **fund only what public money does not cover** (the funding verifier). The deciding fact is whether the public Emergency Response program ran out of capacity last winter; HSH can say.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

WHAT NOBODY COVERED

BLIND SPOT

No one has counted how many people live on the Atwater reach of the river, so most of the funding envelope and both river actions are sized on a guess. A single daylight count by the outreach team in October would change the numbers more than anything else in this briefing. Second, no lens looked at what the river carries after a storm: sewage overflows and bacteria in the soft-bottomed channel are a hazard for the same people who live in it, and the post-storm head count is the moment to check on their health.

HOW TO READ THIS

METHOD

The panel is author-built. Eight simulated expert lenses were used to generate these recommendations. Where they agree, that is a strong hypothesis, not a consensus of the field. Every recommendation was then independently checked for evidence, transferability to this location, and feasibility before the peak; the verdict tags carry the result.

Mortality figures are resolved at Climate Impact Lab impact-region scale, roughly 300,000 people. They are not neighbourhood figures. The El Niño projection covers *heat only*; drought, flood, fire, smoke, and crop failure are additional to it and are carried here by the historical record rather than by a published number.

HOW THIS BRIEFING WAS PRODUCED

METHODOLOGY

- **Scope.** The request named a single street. A street has no data of its own, so the briefing was widened to Atwater Village (ZIP 90039), the neighbourhood it runs through. Glendale ZIP 91204, just to the north, is noted where it differs. Climate Impact Lab impact region, as the report records it: a Los Angeles County region, not resolved. Mortality figures exist only at that scale (impact regions average roughly 300,000 people); sub-city detail is used for hazard exposure and action design, not for death counts.
- **Exposure.** Climate Impact Lab, *451,000 at Risk* (September 2026, pre-peer-review): ECMWF SEAS5 seasonal forecasts (51-member ensemble) applied to temperature–mortality relationships across 24,378 regions, against a 1996–2025 baseline, for June 2026 – February 2027. It covers heat only. It is never added to the Impact Map's long-run projections or quoted from the map's GDP-denominated mortality. Where heat is not the dominant hazard, the historical record carries the hazard instead of a borrowed number.
- **Expert panel.** Eight simulated expert lenses (emergency manager, public health scientist, frontline responder, skeptic, economist, historian, philanthropist, and food supply chain analyst) each researched this place independently and in parallel, from web sources, to a fixed brief.

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They were also given the Woodland Hills briefing (9 October 2026) as Los Angeles context, with its claims treated as claims and re-checked before reuse.

- **Reconciliation.** Duplicate actions were merged and backing lenses recorded. Convergence was tested for shared bias (whether the evidence behind an agreed action came from a setting like this one) before it counted in an action's favour. Contradictions were kept, not resolved by dropping a side. Actions were ranked by expected lives saved per unit of effort before the peak, each was given a named payer and trigger or marked unfunded, and the funding placements were reconciled against the ranked list.
- **Verification.** Six verifier agents checked every recommendation on three tests: evidence (the primary source and its effect size), transferability (whether that evidence came from somewhere like here), and feasibility (whether it can be done here before the peak). Financial actions were also checked for availability in this jurisdiction, a named payer, a trigger threshold, and whether they already exist; the flood-insurance figures were re-queried live from OpenFEMA. Food actions were checked for whether each price series is published at a usable frequency. The funding envelope was checked for real recipients, published unit costs, and duplication, then re-summed. The historical record was checked event by event.
- **Who does what.** The RACI chart is built from the owners named in the verified actions, with one accountable party per action. It is a proposal: no organisation named in it has been contacted or has agreed to a role.
- **Verdicts.** *Confirmed*: evidence, transferability, and feasibility all hold. *Partially confirmed*: holds after the corrections shown. *Unverified*: could not be checked to a primary source. *Contraindicated*: would do harm or waste the window here.
- **Adaptation Inventory.** Not consulted this run: the inventory renders empty without its interface, and its download sits behind a registration form that was not filled in on anyone's behalf. No action here carries a checked precedent from it.
- **Health wording.** Passages where a wording error could hurt someone (cooling and fans, medical equipment in an outage, and backup power) are marked "* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing." They were checked against published sources, not by a health professional. They are suggestions, not medical advice, and anyone passing them on should confirm them with a doctor, pharmacist, nurse, or community health worker first. The marker was added on 2 November 2026.
- **Rules.** No cost is derived by dividing a published total, and no local figure is invented; where data is thin, the report says so and shows the containing geography's number with its arithmetic. Every source is listed below with its verification status.
- **Limits.** The panel and verifiers are AI research agents working from web-available sources, not human experts, and no one in this place was interviewed. The impact region was not resolved. Several pages returned 403 and were checked through search results (LA Public Press,

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Glendale Fire), and the LA Times 2016 river article could not be retrieved. The El Niño phases in the record are from NOAA's ONI as recalled by a verifier, not re-checked. No count exists of people living on this reach.

References · Emergency response and river: LAFD, Fletcher Dr rescue, 16 May 2019 (verified) · LAFD, Glendale Blvd rescue, 28 Dec 2020 (verified) · LAFD, Colorado Blvd airlift, 29 Nov 2018 (verified) · ABC7, Elias Rodriguez, Feb 2017 (verified) · Mayor's office, storm pre-deployment, Nov 2025 (verified) · Abt Associates / Hilton Foundation, LA River basin encampments case study, 2025 (verified) · CD3, 44 people indoors, April 2023 (verified) · LAHSA activation criteria (verified, undated) · 211 LA, winter shelter triggers (verified) · Board of Supervisors motion on storm response (verified) · LA CAO, interim housing and winter bed rates, Nov 2025 (verified) · LA Public Press, Echo Park rain sweep, Feb 2025 (seen via search; 403) · La Opinión, river warnings, 5 Jan 2016 (verified) · Marketplace, people in riverbeds, Nov 2015 (verified) · Council District 13 (verified)
Health and heat: HHS emPOWER ZIP layer (queried 16 Oct 2026) · emPOWER individual dataset rules (verified) · Semenza et al., NEJM 1996 (verified) · Bouchama et al., Arch Intern Med 2007, PMID 17984398 (verified) · Weinberger et al., Environ Int 2021 (verified) · Teisberg, Ebi et al., BAMS 2004 (secondary figures) · Anderson and Bell, Epidemiology 2012 (verified) · Morris et al., Lancet Planetary Health 2021 (verified) · UCLA, cooling-centre use and transit (verified) · LA County cooling centres, August 2026 list (verified) · Unhoused heat deaths, 2022 (verified) · Hollywood Senior Multipurpose Center (verified) · Census Reporter, ZIP 90039 (verified)
Power and money: LADWP EZ-SAVE (verified) · LADWP Cool LA (verified) · LADWP disconnection policies (verified) · LADWP Board, Nov 2022 shutoff motion (verified) · LADWP 2026 Wildfire Mitigation Plan (verified) · OpenFEMA NFIP claims and policies v3 (queried live) · CRS IN10835, NFIP authority (verified) · CDI, FAIR Plan, Aug 2026 (verified) · ProPublica, Ascencia filings (verified)
Food: USDA ERS Food Price Outlook, 25 Sep 2026 (verified) · USDA AMS LA terminal market (verified, daily) · CalFresh work rules, Solis (verified) · Board motion on CalFresh (verified) · CDSS CalFresh data (verified, lagged) · LA Regional Food Bank disaster packs (contents unpublished) · Atwater Village farmers' market, EBT (verified)
Fire, alerts, and record: CBS, Eaton Fire after-action report (verified) · LAFD, Genasys Protect zones (verified) · Eastsider, new fire hazard maps (verified; tier not confirmed) · NOAA CPC ENSO discussion, 8 Oct 2026 (verified) · NOAA CPC seasonal outlook (verified) · USGS, 1969 floods (verified) · NBC LA, El Niño years (verified) · 1933 Griffith Park fire (secondary) · LA Almanac, 2007 fire (verified) · NASA, 2007 fire (verified)
Exposure data · Climate Impact Lab, 451,000 at Risk · Impact Map · Adaptation Inventory
Generated 16 October 2026 for Atwater Village, Los Angeles. El Niño Ready is volunteer-run and is not affiliated with Climate Week NYC, The Climate Group, or Columbia University.

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